CHAPTER 4

BEHIND THE MASK:

HOW TO TACKLE CHALLENGES OF LEADERSHIP IMPOSTORISM

Summary

In this chapter we address the phenomenon of impostorism, why individuals experience it, its impact on leaders and organizations, and strategies to manage it. Drawing on empirical research, popular media, and practical recommendations augmented by our academic expertise, this chapter provides a step-by-step guide to reframe how you view the experience of impostorism. Using a self-reflection exercise and case study, readers can further understand their own experiences of impostorism and build their own 'Impostor Playbook' to explore and overcome it.

Chapter Outline

Introduction

- The Impostor Society: Are You Part of It?
- Impostor Syndrome—Is Something Seriously Wrong With Me?
- Overview of the Chapter

The Many Faces of Impostorism

- The Fear Factor
- The Curses of Perfectionism and Procrastination
- Overwhelming Self-Doubt
- The Never-Ending Cycle

Uncovering the Root Causes

- Inside the Mind of an Impostor: Personality Traits

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The Power of Having a Strong Leader Identity

Beyond the Individual: Some Things Are Out of Our Control

Self-Reflection Tool

Instructions for Impostorism Risk Self-Reflection

The Impostor's Playbook: Practical Strategies for Tackling Leadership Impostorism

Growth Mindset and No Blame Attitude

Self- Compassion

The Vulnerability Advantage: Turning Impostorism Into Your Superpower

Your Network Is Your Friend

No One Succeeds Alone: Why We All Need a Mentor

The Impostorism Paradox: Why Are Impostors (Still) Successful?

The Hidden Upsides of Impostorism

From Impostor to Prime Minister (and Back Again?): The Story of Jacinda Ardern

What Can We Learn From This Example?

Conclusions

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand what leader impostorism is and how common it is in the workplace.

2. Be aware of the different aspects of leader impostorism and how it can have positive or negative outcomes.

3. Understand the common causes of leader impostorism such as personality traits, leader identity, and contextual factors.

4. Be able to reflect upon one's own experiences of leader impostorism using the self-reflection tool provided.

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5. Understand that despite the negative connotations associated with leader impostorism, individuals who experience leader impostorism can still be successful – evidenced by the countless successful individuals who have openly admitted to experiencing it.

Case Questions

Questions for case study on Jacinda Ardern [see *Navigating Leadership*, pp. 73 ff.] :

- What do you think we can learn from Ardern's impostorism story?
- Why do you think she experienced it despite her obvious success? And perhaps most importantly, could she have done anything differently to stop the experience from being overwhelming?
- Now look into the mirror. What do you think you can learn about this for your own leadership experiences— for those times that you may have felt (or may feel in the future) like an impostor in your leadership role?

Personal Development Activities

Instructions for Self-Reflection [see *Navigating Leadership*, p. 66]

Following is a list of statements that relate to common workplace experiences that many leaders face each day. Read each statement carefully and reflect on whether or not you have found yourself in this situation. Further think when you read: How often has it been? How intense is this experience to you? What is the magnitude of this experience? Please write down your thoughts, real-life examples, and reflections as you go through each item below.

1	When I try to think of myself as a leader, I sometimes feel like I am not cut out to be one, because I actually don't have what it takes to successfully manage others.
2	When I think about giving a presentation to a group of colleagues, I am convinced that it will become apparent to other people that I am a fraud and I have been deceiving them.
3	Previously, the thought of starting a new job/ leadership position made me doubt my abilities, and I thought others would perceive me as more capable than I really am.
4	I am worried I would not display my authentic self in leadership positions and thus would have to pretend to be someone else, so others don't find me out.

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5	Thinking about leading a future project, I expect myself to deliver poorly, even though others think that I will be good at it.
6	Because I am different from the other managers and leaders, I struggle to see myself as a leader and therefore I feel like a fraud.
7	When imagining being promoted to a leadership position, I would struggle to accept it as my own accomplishment and not to think that it is a result of their ill judgment.

Interpreting Your Answers

To interpret your answers, determine which of the following two options best describes your own tendency to experience impostorism. Which best captures your experience?

Most of the statements do not apply to me. If you answered "No" to most of the questions above, and do not have many examples and intense memories of these situations, it means that you are at low risk of experiencing leader impostorism. You are likely to be confident in your abilities and skills and you feel comfortable in your role as a leader. You feel like you can be yourself in the workplace most of the time and you don't have to pretend to be someone you are not. In most situations where you must speak in front of people or give presentations, you may be nervous, but you are still your authentic self. However, there is always room for improvement, and while it appears that you are not plagued by experiencing impostorism, you can use your self-confidence to engage in targeted development activities.	**Most of the statements apply to me**. Your experiences suggest that you are more likely to feel impostorism as a leader. You experience a more regular fear of being found out as a fraud and you doubt that you have earned your accomplishments based on merit. You may even suspect that others' misjudgements of your abilities and skills have brought you to where you are now. These feelings may cause you unnecessary stress and emotional discomfort in the workplace. You may find that self- doubt is creeping up on you in many situations at work, for example, when you must give presentations or need to prove your worth. However, the information and tools contained in this chapter— especially those which follow— can help you to manage your leadership impostorism.

The Impostor's Playbook

A playbook is a collection of plans and procedures that support the navigation of complex scenarios and ultimately achieve success. As with any playbook, you will find that some "plays" work best in certain situations and some in others. So, students should explore the

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options provided in the chapter to identify which strategies they think would work best for them, why that option and in what scenario (think back to the self-reflection statements) would it help the most.

Table 4.1 gives you an overview of your options. Your first option is to focus on yourself and create a "no blame" mindset, meaning that you try and see the potential for improvement in your actions. Secondly, engaging in self-compassion techniques will help you to forgive yourself for potential mistakes. Next, we encourage you to see vulnerability and authenticity as an advantage that can set you free from the daunting experience of feeling like a fraud. Lastly, we offer two ways to engage your social network and use it as a source of reassurance and support, by seeking out interactions with peers and utilizing the experience of a mentor.

Work with self	Work with others
Change your mindset: Develop a growth mindset and no blame attitude	Your network is your friend: Use networking to your advantage
Overcome impostorism with self-compassion	No one succeeds alone: Why we all need a mentor
The vulnerability advantage: Turn impostorism into your superpower	

Key Reading

Kark, R., Meister, A., & Peters, K. (2022). Now you see me, now you don't: A conceptual model of the antecedents and consequences of leader impostorism. *Journal of Management*, 48(7), 1948– 1979.

Further Reading

Neureiter, M., & Traut- Mattausch, E. (2016). An inner barrier to career development: Preconditions of the impostor phenomenon and consequences for career development. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 7, 173631.

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Tewfik, B. A. (2022). The impostor phenomenon revisited: Examining the relationship between workplace impostor thoughts and interpersonal effectiveness at work. *Academy of Management Journal*, 65(3), 988– 1018.

Other Recommended Sources

Ardern, J. (2020). Open minded— Ep.5 Rt Hon Jacinda Ardern — full video. Youtube. https:// www.yout ube.com/ watch?v= MGKw czxm 0pQ

Roy, E. R. (2020), December 21). Jacinda Ardern: I try to turn self- doubt into “something more positive”. The Guardian. 21 December 21. https:// www.theg uard ian.com/ world/ 2020/ dec/ 21/jacinda-ardern-i-try-to-turn-selfdoubt-into- something- more- positive

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